

The 88 Constellations

A Comprehensive Bilingual Catalogue of the Modern Sky

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Abstract

This paper presents a comprehensive catalogue of all 88 officially recognised constellations as defined by the International Astronomical Union (IAU) in 1930. Each entry lists the Latin name, official three-letter IAU abbreviation, the popular title given to the constellation figure (such as Orion the Great Hunter), and its Bangla name in Bengali script. Constellations are arranged alphabetically. The work is intended as a bilingual reference for amateur astronomers, educators, and students of astronomy in the Bengali-speaking world.

1. Introduction

A constellation is a formally defined region of the celestial sphere associated with a recognised star pattern and the figure or object it represents. The modern system of 88 constellations was standardised in 1930 by Belgian astronomer Eugène Delporte, based on proposals by Henry Norris Russell. Together they tile the entire celestial sphere without overlap or gap. Of the 88, some 48 were catalogued in the 2nd century by the Greek astronomer Ptolemy in his *Almagest*. The remaining 40 were added by European navigators and astronomers from the 15th to the 19th centuries to chart the southern sky unfamiliar to the ancient Greeks.

1.1 How to Use This Catalogue

Each row in the catalogue provides four pieces of information:

- **Name:** Latin name of the constellation.
- **IAU:** Official three-letter abbreviation.
- **Known As:** The evocative title astronomers and storytellers give the figure.
- **Bangla Name:** The corrected, standard name rendered in Bengali script.

2. The 88 Constellations: Full Catalogue

Name	IAU	Known As	Bangla Name
Andromeda	And	The Chained Princess	অ্যান্ড্রোমিডা

Name	IAU	Known As	Bangla Name
Antlia	Ant	The Air Pump	বায়ু পাম্প
Apus	Aps	The Bird of Paradise	স্বর্গীয় পাখি
Aquarius	Aqr	The Water Bearer	কুম্ভ
Aquila	Aql	The Soaring Eagle	ঈগল
Ara	Ara	The Sacred Altar	বেদি
Aries	Ari	The Golden Ram	মেঘ
Auriga	Aur	The Charioteer	সারথি
Boötes	Boo	The Herdsman	রক্ষক / রাখাল
Caelum	Cae	The Engraver's Chisel	ছেনি
Camelopardalis	Cam	The Giraffe	জিরাফ
Cancer	Cnc	The Crab	কর্কট
Canes Venatici	CVn	The Hunting Dogs	শিকারী কুকুর
Canis Major	CMa	The Great Dog	বৃহৎ কুকুর
Canis Minor	CMi	The Little Dog	ক্ষুদ্র কুকুর
Capricornus	Cap	The Sea Goat	মকর
Carina	Car	The Keel of the Ship Argo	জাহাজের তলদেশ / তরণী
Cassiopeia	Cas	The Vain Queen	রানী ক্যাসিওপিয়া
Centaurus	Cen	The Centaur	সেন্টর
Cepheus	Cep	The King of Ethiopia	রাজা সিফিয়াস
Cetus	Cet	The Sea Monster	সমুদ্র দানব / তিমি
Chamaeleon	Cha	The Chameleon	গিরগিটি

Name	IAU	Known As	Bangla Name
Circinus	Cir	The Compass	কম্পাস
Columba	Col	The Dove	কবুতর / কপোত
Coma Berenices	Com	Berenice's Hair	বেরেনিসের চুল / কেশ
Corona Australis	CrA	The Southern Crown	দক্ষিণের মুকুট
Corona Borealis	CrB	The Northern Crown	উত্তর মুকুট
Corvus	Crv	The Crow	কাক
Crater	Crt	The Cup of Apollo	পানপাত্র
Crux	Cru	The Southern Cross	দক্ষিণ ত্রুশ
Cygnus	Cyg	The Swan	রাজহাঁস / বকমণ্ডল
Delphinus	Del	The Dolphin	ডলফিন
Dorado	Dor	The Swordfish	তরবারি মাছ
Draco	Dra	The Dragon	ড্রাগন
Equuleus	Equ	The Little Foal	অশ্বশাবক
Eridanus	Eri	The River Eridanus	নদী
Fornax	For	The Furnace	চুল্লি
Gemini	Gem	The Twin Brothers	মিথুন
Grus	Gru	The Crane	সারস
Hercules	Her	Hercules the Great Hero	হারকিউলিস
Horologium	Hor	The Pendulum Clock	ঘড়ি
Hydra	Hya	The Water Serpent	জলসাপ / হাইড্রা
Hydrus	Hyi	The Lesser Water Snake	ক্ষুদ্র জলসাপ

Name	IAU	Known As	Bangla Name
Indus	Ind	The Indian	আদিবাসী / ভারতীয়
Lacerta	Lac	The Lizard	টিকটিকি
Leo	Leo	The Lion	সিংহ
Leo Minor	LMi	The Little Lion	ক্ষুদ্র সিংহ
Lepus	Lep	The Hare	খরগোশ
Libra	Lib	The Scales of Justice	তুলা
Lupus	Lup	The Wolf	নেকড়ে
Lynx	Lyn	The Lynx	বনবিড়াল
Lyra	Lyr	The Lyre of Orpheus	লাইরা / বীণা
Mensa	Men	Table Mountain	টেবিল পর্বত
Microscopium	Mic	The Microscope	অণুবীক্ষণ যন্ত্র
Monoceros	Mon	The Unicorn	একশৃঙ্গ অশ্ব
Musca	Mus	The Fly	মাছি
Norma	Nor	The Set Square	নিয়মক / সমকোণী পরিমাপক
Octans	Oct	The Octant	অষ্টমাংশ যন্ত্র / অষ্টভুজ যন্ত্র
Ophiuchus	Oph	The Serpent Bearer	সর্পধারী
Orion	Ori	Orion the Great Hunter	কালপুরুষ / শিকারী ওরিয়ন
Pavo	Pav	The Peacock	ময়ূর
Pegasus	Peg	The Winged Horse	পক্ষীরাজ
Perseus	Per	Perseus the Hero	পার্সিয়াস
Phoenix	Phe	The Phoenix	ফিনিক্স পাখি

Name	IAU	Known As	Bangla Name
Pictor	Pic	The Painter's Easel	চিত্রকরের ইজেল
Pisces	Psc	The Two Fish	মীন
Piscis Austrinus	PsA	The Southern Fish	দক্ষিণ মৎস্য
Puppis	Pup	The Stern of the Argo	জাহাজের পশ্চাৎভাগ
Pyxis	Pyx	The Mariner's Compass	নাবিকের কম্পাস
Reticulum	Ret	The Reticle	জালক
Sagitta	Sge	The Arrow	তীর
Sagittarius	Sgr	The Archer	ধনু
Scorpius	Sco	The Scorpion	বৃশ্চিক
Sculptor	Scl	The Sculptor	ভাস্কর
Scutum	Sct	The Shield	ঢাল
Serpens	Ser	The Serpent	সাপ
Sextans	Sex	The Sextant	সেক্সট্যান্ট
Taurus	Tau	The Bull	বৃষ
Telescopium	Tel	The Telescope	দূরবীক্ষণ যন্ত্র
Triangulum	Tri	The Triangle	ত্রিকোণ
Triangulum Australe	TrA	The Southern Triangle	দক্ষিণ ত্রিকোণ
Tucana	Tuc	The Toucan	টুকান পাখি
Ursa Major	UMa	The Great Bear	সপ্তর্ষিমণ্ডল
Ursa Minor	UMi	The Little Bear	লঘু সপ্তর্ষি / ক্ষুদ্র ভাল্লুক
Vela	Vel	The Sails of the Argo	পাল

Name	IAU	Known As	Bangla Name
Virgo	Vir	Virgo the Maiden	কন্যা
Volans	Vol	The Flying Fish	উড়ন্ত মাছ
Vulpecula	Vul	The Little Fox	খেকশিয়াল / শাবক

3. Notes on the Constellations

3.1 Origins and Mythology

The majority of the northern constellations derive from ancient Mesopotamian, Greek, and Roman mythology. The 48 constellations listed by Ptolemy remain in use today, though their boundaries have been formally delineated. Many of the southern constellations were named by European navigators and astronomers in the 15th-19th centuries, including Petrus Plancius, Johann Bayer, Nicolas Louis de Lacaille, and Johannes Hevelius.

3.2 The IAU Standardisation of 1930

Prior to 1930, constellation boundaries were vague and overlapping, causing confusion in star catalogues. At the request of the IAU, Eugène Delporte drew precise boundaries along lines of right ascension and declination as they stood in epoch 1875.0, using a proposal by Henry Norris Russell as the basis. The resulting 88 constellations cover the entire celestial sphere and have been universally adopted ever since.

3.3 Bangla Naming Conventions

The Bangla names in this catalogue follow two conventions:

- Translation:** Where a meaningful Bengali equivalent exists, the classical term is used. The 12 zodiacal constellations are particularly well-established, corresponding directly to the rāśi (রাশি) of Jyotish (Indian classical astronomy): Aries = মেষ, Taurus = বৃষ, Gemini = মিতুন, Cancer = কর্কট, Leo = সিংহ, Virgo = কন্যা, Libra = তুলা, Scorpius = বৃশ্চিক, Sagittarius = ধনু, Capricornus = মকর, Aquarius = কুম্ভ, Pisces = মীন.
- Transliteration:** Where no established Bengali term exists, the Latin name is rendered phonetically in Bengali script (e.g., Andromeda = অ্যান্ড্রোমিডা).

3.4 Seasonal Visibility from Bangladesh

From the latitude of Dhaka ($\approx 23.7^\circ$ N), most northern-hemisphere constellations are visible at some point during the year, as are many southern constellations.

Seasonal Highlights:

- **Winter (Dec–Feb):** Orion the Great Hunter (কালপুরুষ / শিকারী ওরিয়ন), Taurus the Bull (বৃষ), Gemini the Twins (মিথুন), Canis Major the Great Dog (বৃহৎ কুকুর)
- **Spring (Mar–May):** Leo the Lion (সিংহ), Virgo the Maiden (কন্যা), Boötes the Herdsman (বক্ষক / রাখাল)
- **Summer (Jun–Aug):** Scorpius the Scorpion (বৃশ্চিক), Sagittarius the Archer (ধনু), Cygnus the Swan (রাজহাঁস)
- **Autumn (Sep–Nov):** Pegasus the Winged Horse (পক্ষীরাজ), Andromeda the Chained Princess (অ্যান্ড্রোমিডা), Aquarius the Water Bearer (কুম্ভ)

4. Conclusion

The 88 IAU constellations constitute the universal language of positional astronomy, enabling astronomers worldwide to unambiguously identify regions of the sky. This bilingual catalogue — presented in Latin and Bengali — aims to make the rich heritage of constellation lore more accessible to Bengali-speaking readers, students, and sky-watchers. It is hoped that this work will inspire greater engagement with astronomy in the Bengali-speaking world, where the night sky has been observed, named, and celebrated for millennia.

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